**Nobody's Perfect**

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# Nobody's Perfect

by fleurjaune (fleur_jaune)

Summary

Gabriel’s hands still on his ring. There was nothing wrong in Adrien’s reaction per se. He doesn’t know how else he expected Adrien to respond.
Technically Adrien’s reaction was completely correct. It was what he’d want from his son.

Happiness. Gratitude. An Eagerness to please.

And yet he can’t but think that something seems off.

# Chapter 1: Realisations

It's how Adrien fiddles with his ring that had drawn Gabriel's attention to it back when he'd considered the possibility of Adrien being Chat Noir.

Recently he's noticed his son doing it again. It's a bad habit to be forming, a crutch for Adrien's unease and an obvious tell. Gabriel should shut this right down now.

Only right now, as Adrien's twisting his ring around requesting to add another classmate to the group at the award ceremony despite the fact Gabriel has oh-so-kindly already invited a bunch of them (to aid him in his attempts to defeat Ladybug and Chat Noir admittedly but *Adrien* hardly knows that), Gabriel is doing exactly the same thing with his (no, *with Emilie's* ) wedding ring.

Though *he* at least has the sense to do it behind his back. Stand like that enough and people won't notice when you do it to cover uncertainty. People won't even think you *have* uncertainty.

Indeed sometimes he thinks even *Emilie* hadn't always noticed. Nathalie does, though she doesn't mention it Gabriel has noticed the small actions she takes to smooth his path and he thanks his lucky stars he had the sense to hire her, but Nathalie alone knows the worst of him and still holds faith in him somehow.

So.

Adrien should stop doing it. And Adrien shouldn't *need* to do it. He's like Emilie, not like *him.* Dealing with people and putting on the mask to get what you want from them isn't difficult for *Adrien.* The boy does it as easily as breathing just as his mother had. It's what made them such good models.

Still.

Gabriel does vaguely recall this being an awkward age though generally he just tries to forget his teenagerhood. Adrien's just as perfect as Emilie had always said he was but given their son has his fits of rebellion he guesses he might have his fits of awkwardness too.

"She can go," he halts Adrien's stuttering request. He's allowed too many of the others to have a good reason to say no and they're just wasting time he could be plotting in, "providing Nathalie can confirm her previous behaviour is acceptable. Go ask her."

Adrien straightens up and deploys his most blinding smile, the one he inherited from Emilie in exactness and says, "Of course Father. Thank you. I'll go ask her."

Then his son doesn't quite run on.

Gabriel's hands still on his ring. There was nothing *wrong* in Adrien's reaction per se. He doesn't know how else he expected Adrien to respond.

Technically Adrien's reaction was completely correct. It was what he'd *want* from his son.

Happiness. Gratitude. An Eagerness to please.

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Adrien stands there, every bit as forthright in his opinions as Emilie used to be in hers, blazing with indignation as if *he'd* not the one who's just betrayed his family.

"Go to your room," Gabriel cuts him off icily and thinks that Adrien is lucky that *he's* his father and not his grandfather. Gabriel would have been in for a walloping if he'd made a spectacle of himself the way Adrien had today.

The fight drains out of Adrien immediately, and the boy turns to obey.

And that's *normal.* That's what he expects, it's exactly what he's trained Adrien to do.

But usually, *usually,* they'd be something more. A slight stomp to the Adrien's steps as he goes up stairs, or a tightness of subsumed anger in Adrien's jaw. Obedience yes, and a sulking sort of obedience.

Not this ready surrender almost as if Adrien was talking his mother who'd always been able to sweeten any annoyance and get Gabriel and Adrien alike to concede.

Gabriel isn't his wife. He holds to his rules and strictness because that's the only way he *knows* how to control people. It works well enough at work. It works less well at home or Adrien wouldn't be at school, and Nathalie wouldn't be upstairs confined to her bed, and Emilie wouldn't be in her endless sleep below.

But right now it seems to be working perfectly.

Something is off here.

---

He doesn't know why *it* matters.

Adrien is doing exactly what Gabriel wants.

It's what he *wanted* isn't it?

Still he finds himself pushing. Denying Adrien's every request even when there's no need to, just to see how his son reacts.

Nathalie has started to notice he knows. There's a slight dissatisfaction in the furrow of her brows whenever the topic of Adrien comes in between them. He finds himself having to distract her by appealing to her cunning with new plans or by busying himself in caring for *her* (something really quite necessary given her lack of care for herself) which always provokes such a charming confusion in her eyes as she tries to refuse him.

But the idea of admitting what he's doing to her makes him feel small.

What could he tell her? That he's concerned Adrien's being *too* obedient?

Ridiculous. Especially with how the boy still sneaks out at times. Gabriel had had to shut himself away in the Atelier to *scream* after he'd found the boy's phone propped up on his piano playing music and no evidence of Adrien himself after one akuma attack.

To think Adrien hadn't even taken his *phone.* He could have been anywhere in Paris and Gabriel would have had no idea. He could have been *kidnapped.*

Adrien had flinched back at the telling-off he'd given him after *that.*

Indeed he might grinding Adrien's wilfulness down but his son still has his flares of revolt. In this at least Adrien's no perfect filial child. He's just the boy he's always known his son to be. Well-behaved but as mulish as his mother when he gets a bee in his bonnet.

So he's not really sure what's concerning him and *yet* something is.

There's no pattern he can find in when Adrien's attempts at mutiny crumble and when the boy stands firm even in defeat.

And *yet.*

*And yet.*

---

The sharp edge of his screen digs into his forehead as he wakes up. His head hurts but whether it's from the dent it's no doubt left there or just the lack of sleep giving him a headache he's not sure.

Nathalie's right. He does need to sleep more.

But there's never the time. Not with work. Not with Hawk Moth. Not with Nathalie still unable to fully take her place by his side for either.

The world feels fuzzy and hazy as if he hasn't quite woken up. The moon casts odd shadows around the Atelier making it almost seem like he's in quite another room. A funhouse mirror version of the place where he spends most of his life.

He smiles at the idea. A world where what, Emilie was alive and he not? Would Adrien be a true rebel there or would he be—

That's it.

He grips the screen in front of him before his legs can collapse beneath him.

*Mindlessly Obedient.*

*That's* the difference. *That's* what he sees flashes of in his son. *That's* why he feels so unsettled by it.

He wants Adrien's obedience but not mindlessly. He wants it to come from the respect due to him as Adrien's *father (*he doesn't dare hope for it to be out of love the way it had been for Adrien's *mother).* He wants it to come from Adrien understanding they want the best for him. Not because his son is incapable of aught else.

Anyway the idea is ridiculous. There's nothing that would cause that in Adrien.

Or not nothing.

But nothing Gabriel's *used.*

It's not like he keeps his son akumatised every day of his life.

---

The idea is ridiculous.

---

The idea is ridiculous.

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The idea is—

“You or Nathalie will have to tell Mlle. Bustier I can’t work on the group project,” Adrien says, “I understand we can’t have anyone over to the house but she’ll listen to you two more than she would to me.”

Gabriel’s thrown by the sudden change. Adrien had been asking for permission to have two of his classmates to the house to work on some homework, and Gabriel had been thinking how impossible it was, how he couldn’t risk everything by letting two random teenagers in to poke around and think god knows what, and then his son had suddenly done a total 180.

Helpful except-

*Gabriel had never said a word out loud.*

It was as if Adrien had responded to his thoughts.

Which is impossible.

Isn’t it?

“Talk to Nathalie about how you can work in this project,” he tells Adrien even as the cogs in his mind turn and turn and turn, “I can’t why you can’t collaborate virtually when I do.”

A school project is hardly a multinational business, but honestly Gabriel doesn’t care about that. He cares about how his son is reacting to his thoughts.

Had he been Nathalie then Gabriel would have written it off as just her usual skill in reading him but Adrien doesn't know him the way his assistant does.

So this is.

This is inexplicable.

He releases his hands letting go of his ring.

His ring.

*Emilie’s* ring.

Gabriel could throw up.

---

It’s strange transforming with just the Peacock but he can’t dare a distraction when it comes to something this important.

When it comes to *Adrien.*

But Gabriel's little practice with reaching out looking for other people's amoks. Still. He doubts it will matter. He had little practice using a Miraculous at all once upon a time and now he does just fine.

Besides all of this is a coincidence. It *has* to be.

The alternative-

The alternative is totally mad.

That *his (*Emilie's) *wedding ring* is a sentimonster with the power to control someone.

It's their *wedding bands.* The very symbol of their promises to each other. Emilie wouldn't have mocked their marriage like that.

Besides if she would do *that,* could compel obedience then all their other experiments and usage of the Butterfly and the Peacock would be pointless.

Anyway he'd have noticed before. It's *on his hand,* it's right there, he would have *noticed,* so this must be, has to be, nothing.

Only.

As his mind reaches out to the ring on his finger there *is* something there.

It's hard to grasp. Oddly slippery to his mind as if it's coated in some sort of repellent that makes him look away. He seems somehow unable to focus on it.

It's too bright to look at. Too dark to look at. Too small to pick up. Too large to get his hands around. Every signal he gets back to his brain is the confusion of another sense.

It's not a sentimonster.

It's not an amok.

But it's something.

---

So just as he had when they were looking for the leads about the missing temple, just as he had when Emilie started to fall ill, he does what he always do and goes to Nathalie.

"I don't understand," she says.

“Here,” he says and reaching out and takes the Peacock Miraculous from his chest and hands it to her.

Her eyes go wide and her hands process to take the Miraculous from his is slow, “you’re letting me?”

“It’s fixed isn’t it?” He says more lightly than he feels, “And you’re,”

Her lips quirk up at the side. “Not fixed?”

“No,” he agrees because she’s *not* better, not yet and that’s why he can’t let her take Mayura’s mantle back up when all her energy should go to her recovery but, “you are getting better. And this can’t hurt you now.”

Her hand closes over the brooch. “Not *physically* anyway.”

He sighs letting his eyes close, “It’s probably nothing. I’m *sure* it’s nothing. She always had stories about those rings. It’s probably just that.”

The flash of Mayura’s transformation permeates through his eyelids and he opens them to see Hawk Moth’s devoted ally in front of him.

Despite the circumstances he almost smiles to see her and her does much the same, but then the smile falls off her face, and she grasps for his hand almost squashing it in her grip.

Her panic is contagious and suddenly there’s a lump in his throat, “Mayura?*”*

She does some complicated motion with her other hand, “it’s, it’s *shielded* I think, I’ve read of this but I never thought I’d see it, I mean it’s hardly of us to but,”

“Shielded? Shielding *what?*”

“Gabriel,” she looks up and horror fills her pink eyes, “Gabriel, I think there’s an amok in there.”

“No,” he says, pulling his hand out of hers and standing up away from her on the bed, “No, no they’re can’t be. *No.”*

He’d strike out to hit the wall as if he could pummel sense back into the world but Nathalie attempts to stand to follow him, and even as *Mayura* she seems to sway and he turns to catch the only person in his life he’s sure of these days.

He helps her back down but doesn’t release her, and she whispers her detransformation still in his arms.

“It could be anything,” Nathalie says, “we don’t know what Emilie was doing with that ring.”

“No,” he swallows, “you don’t understand. Adrien *obeys* me with it.”

“Adrien usually does obey you.” She pauses. “Usually.”

Nathalie hasn't seen the dullness in Adrien's eyes. The loss of his personality. "Not like this. Not like this."

Overcome by sudden nausea he lets go of Nathalie to run into her bathroom before he can throw up.

---

The door to her room creaks open, "Nathalie?"

Gabriel blinks the sleepiness out of his eyes in confusion as to why Adrien is looking for Nathalie in his room.

Ah.

He's not in his room.

He remembers collapsing against Nathalie and crying until he had no more tears to spend. No more energy to spend apparently if he'd fallen asleep here. Nathalie been crying too he thinks.

Then he remembers *why* he was crying.

"*Father?*" Adrien's voice comes up slightly strangled and when his forces himself to look up his son is gaping at them with embarrassment painting his cheeks red.

Nathalie's eyes are open too at this stage with a splotchy blush of her own making its way up the her neck to her face.

He sighs, and reaches for the ring, "You'll forget this Adrien. Go to school."

The shock melts off his son's face, "I'll just go to school."

Nathalie's gasp almost isn't audible, but once Adrien has left she whispers, "you weren't exaggerating."

"No," how he wishes he was, "I wasn't."

---

He doesn't understand. He tries and tries and tries but he doesn't and unless he regains Emilie then he never will.

It just doesn't make sense. *Any* of it.

Emilie had never mentioned any of this.

And Emilie, she'd, "she was *pregnant.* I shared a bed with her at night, I saw her in the bathroom she can't have faked that to *me.* It's not possible."

Nathalie runs her hands through her hair. She's more dishevelled than he's ever seen her and he knows he's no better.

"She might not have she might,"

"What? Are you going to tell me my *real* son died one day and my wife just what, hid his body somewhere, and replaced him with a magical clone? That's-" then he remembers where his wife is, "not as impossible as it should be is it? Oh my god, Nathalie what am I meant to do?"

"Could," Nathalie's mouth twists even as her frown heralds the thoughts in her brain, "she have created the sentimonster *inside* her womb somehow? If he can grow from a baby to a teenager then why not earlier?"

He stares at her, "is that supposed to be *better?"*

She purses her lips, "It doesn't include Adrien dying."

Her concern for his son when *he's* more concerned with what his son is stabs him in his chest and he collapses down beside her. "I suppose you're right. But then," if Adrien *died* then Gabriel has a way to revive him even if that means giving up Emilie but if Adrien is a sentimonster, if Adrien has *always* been a sentimonster then Gabriel has no idea what that means for any of them, "what do we do about it?"

"Well." Nathalie says. "I suppose that depends."

"On what?"

Her eyes meet his. "Do you still consider him your son?"

---

Adrien is perfect.

Emilie had always said that.

Gabriel had believed it.

Adrien is perfect.

The perfect son, the perfect heir, the perfect heir to his brand.

It rings differently now.

It’s easy for a doll to be perfect. Meticulously created to be so by its creator. Only expressing what they want.

But Adrien *doesn’t.*

---

Adrien isn’t perfect.

Adrien’s dramatic, and he cares about things Gabriel doesn’t give a fig for. Adrien’s stubborn and it’s the bane of Gabriel's life. Adrien is hardworking and clever but without Nathalie’s tuition he wouldn’t have top-marks in every subject.

Adrien *isn’t* perfect.

Adrien’s human.

And Adrien’s an Agreste.

---

“I, that,” Nathalie watches him unceasingly as he struggles, “Adrien *is* my son.”

Adrien’s the only one he has. And he’s all he has of Emilie and for all he's starting to think he might hate her for this he thinks that might still matter.

---

Gabriel brings no flower to Emilie’s coffin.

Instead he stands there railing accusations at a woman who can’t defend herself.

Her gentle expression seems to mock him and for the first time he’s hit by how unnatural this all looks with her suspended like that.

He’s almost tempted to go get a hammer and smash through the glass to see if she’s even really there.

To see if this is just another trick she’s played on him.

There's an infinitesimal relaxation in Nathalie's shoulders, "*then,"* she says, "we work out how to protect him."

# Chapter 2: Repercussions

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The sound of Adrien happily chatting to his bodyguard in the hall sets his nerves on edge. Gabriel hasn't seen his son since discovering *what* Adrien is.

Or what Gabriel *thinks* he *probably* is anyway.

Nathalie had thought there was something strange about the amok, something more complex there than just the shielding on the ring and maybe she's right. Maybe there *is* something more to what Adrien is than just a sentimonster. Maybe there was a real boy there to begin with.

Or maybe they're both just looking for what they want to believe.

He rues the lack of Nathalie's presence at the entry of the Atelier to deny Adrien entry. It would make things so much easier. So much easier to pretend he never knew this. So much easier to push Adrien aside entirely the way he has the rest of Emilie's ideas that he only tolerated for her.

As it is he's tempted to use the lift to flee every time he hears Adrien walk past. The fear of Adrien catching him in that action is the only thing stopping him.

Of course he could make Adrien forget the same way he made Adrien forget finding him in Nathalie's bed that morning.

But that defeats the very purpose of avoiding Adrien.

Oh it's in part because the idea of seeing the boy Emilie's made both repulses and draws him in.

He wants to hide in here and pretend he never realised. Pretend that Adrien *is* just a normal human boy. Pretend Adrien's his son in the simple literal way and not the more tangled mess of ties made of the years they're had together, and their public image, and their love for Emilie.

He wants to watch Adrien every second of the day. To see if Adrien is as real a person as he always thought he was before he discovered he could command him to be otherwise. To see what flaws exist or if Emilie was the perfectionist here she was in everything else. To see if anyone else could tell or if it's just how little time Gabriel's spent with Adrien that's let him be wilfully blind.

It wasn't *deliberate* little time. It's just that he had the company to run and Emilie was just *better* with their son but now just as with everything else he has to question that, and if that apparently eminently sensible split had in fact been wholly her idea.

But what has won out over those warring impulses and forced him into avoidance is that Gabriel doesn't *know* how to not command his son.

*Not* telling Adrien what to do is never something he's felt the need to think about doing before but the thing is that *sometimes* the magic hadn't made his son obey him.

It wouldn't have until he had *Emilie's* ring obviously. He's certain this never happened with his own. But even since then Adrien hadn't obeyed *every* time.

What had made the difference?

Gabriel doesn't know.

Had he been touching the ring?

It touches his skin the whole time he wears it. It doesn't feel like that should make a difference.

Had he, *no,* it can't be a certain set of words because that once Adrien had reacted to him without him saying a thing.

Had he *wanted* Adrien to obey him those times more than others?

He'd like to say no. He'd like to think that anything he asks his son to do is important but perhaps…perhaps he's got into the habit of telling Adrien no or having him do such and such when he doesn't really *need* to.

It *could* be that it only kicks in the more important the command is to him. It's plausible. It works as an explanation.

But it could still be something totally different too.

Perhaps he's just bonding more with the ring over time, and *that* would mean Adrien will only begin to follow his wishes more and more over time.

The problem is he doesn't know.

And if he doesn't know *how* he commands Adrien then he doesn't know how *not* to command Adrien.

Funny how he'd never thought Adrien doing what he wanted would be a bad thing. He'd complained about his tendency to do the opposite enough times.

But he wants a *son.* Not an automaton.  No matter how convenient the latter might be the idea makes his skin crawl.

He doesn't understand how it didn't Emilie's.

But for now the easiest way to achieve that; the easiest way to let Adrien *be* Adrien and not just Gabriel's puppet is for Gabriel to stay away from him.

And it's not difficult and that does give him a flicker of unease.

---

Sometimes he wonders if somewhere deep down he *knew.* If that's why he's always struggled to connect to Adrien even when his son had been too young to have preferences of his own.

If that's why he's always felt the need to surround himself with images of his son to remind himself he has a son. If be the very action of *making* Adrien the face of the brand had been him trapping himself into making Adrien someone too public to ignore.

That feels like giving himself too much credit.

And anyway, hadn't some of it been *Emilie's* idea?

That rings differently now.

---

In his head he runs over and over his conversations with Emilie about Adrien. Had she ever hinted at it? Did she think he knew and she didn't need to?

Emile had often thought of him as better than he was. Look at how she'd trusted him to revive her. He'd liked that once. Having someone that believed in him. It had spurred him on. But now he knows she at least somewhat *made* Adrien it starts to feel like perhaps she was making *him* into what she wanted to.

All to the good of course. He likes being wealthy and successful and respected but he's not so sure he likes the idea that he doesn't know what she did to help him get there.

It's not as if he hasn't always credited her with most of his success. With another chunk of credit going to Nathalie of course for keeping this whole thing going. But Emilie's charisma and contacts had been invaluable.

Still. If she didn't tell him *this* then he doesn't know what else she didn't tell him.

Her portrait looms behind him and for the first time in years Gabriel has no desire to turn to see it.

---

Nathalie turns her head away from his tablet to frown at him, “you *don’t* want Adrien to come to the show?”

He shifts uneasily and his thigh brushes against hers through the duvet separating them but Nathalie doesn’t react and he has no choice but to admit, “I don't think it's a good idea.”

Adrien isn't in this show. He's too young yet to make more than the odd appearance on the catwalk, but usually he'd come and sit in the front row and informally model anyway.

But Gabriel hasn’t seen Adrien since he realised he's not quite human and he's still no closer to knowing how this magic works, despite all Nathalie’s desperate attempts at research. It’s one advantage to her bedrest at least that she has the time to devote to it.

“But,” she hesitates, “he’s, I won’t say nothing has changed because everything has, but he’s already been like this at least since before you lost Emilie. He’ll be confused at the change in his routine.”

“Will he be?” Gabriel shakes his head, “I don’t even know *what* he thinks. How can I? I don’t *want* him to notice so he won’t. Isn’t that how it works?”

Nathalie goes pale and he can’t help but worry. “I don’t think that’s. That,” she swallows suddenly.

Panicked he reaches out to steady her, “Are you alright?”

“Fine,” she says, and shakes off his hand, but she’s clearly lying, “It’s just,”

“Just *what?*”

“Well. If you don’t want that to happen shouldn’t we give *Adrien* the ring? That’s how it works isn’t it? We’ve seen that.”

The spectre of her failed Ladybug hangs between them.

And she *is* right. Giving Adrien the ring would mean that *Adrien* would be the only person able to command himself. Or command himself in a way that couldn’t be disobeyed anyway. Gabriel wants his son to be exactly as controllable as any human boy is, no more and no less, not for Adrien to go running wild all over the city.

And yet he can’t give Adrien the ring, and so he tells her, “No.”

Nathalie’s face betrays that it’s not the answer she was expecting even before she says. “No?”

“No,” he confirms, “How could we explain it to Adrien? Hello, son please take what you believe is my wedding ring but is actually your mother’s because your cousin stole mine so I took it from your mother who hasn’t disappeared but lies in an endless sleep deep below us because she drove herself to death with a broken Miraculous by creating magical creatures including apparently you?”

Nathalie stares at him, “I’m not sure,”

“No, I know.” He agrees, because he understands her objections and, “We’d hardly have to tell him *all* of that. But Nathalie, if we don’t then how can we make sure he understands the seriousness of the situation? What if he takes it off?” After all Adrien already wears one ring he seems quite attached to on his hand he might not want another, “What if he loses it? What if someone steals it from him?”

“But, Gabriel. That could happen to *you* too.”

“I know.” Not that he plans to let Félix back inside this house anytime soon but if one sheltered teenage boy can manage it then unfortunately that means much of the world is a danger in this case.

A danger to Adrien’s life.

Nathalie just looks at him in that way she has, as if she understands all his hopes and fears, and places her hand over his.

It makes it suddenly very easy to make a choice.

He looks up from their joined hands and meets her gaze, “would you wear it?”

Her eyes widen, “*What?”*

“I can’t,” he tries to explain, “it’s too important to leave it in the house and just hope it’s safe. I need it to be with someone I trust. And that’s *you.* I’ll even take Adrien to the show like I’m supposed to if you do.”

“But I could still,”

He’d seen her objection coming, “I trust you. And I think there has to be *intention* for him to act on his desires. Or possibly distance effects it too.”

“And I don’t see Adrien as much as you do.”

“You’re get better,” he’s trying to convince himself as much as her, “this won’t be forever, and then we’ll go back to you seeing him every day and we’ll have to re-assess how we’re going to do this. But in the meantime it’s the best thing I can think of, and besides you’re better with the Peacock than I am. You always have been. I think maybe Emilie was too. I never noticed that Adrien acted like this before.”

He’d never noticed Adrien robotically obeying *her.*

In fact Emilie had always been the softer of the two of them. She’d been good with all Adrien’s various moods and whims and talking him down but she’d always come to *him* when their son needed any form of discipline or even just for a hard line to be drawn in what Adrien could or couldn’t do.

Maybe that was because she *couldn’t* without re-writing their son’s entire personality.

Nathalie sighs, “I’ll do it.”

“You will?”

“I don’t know if it’s a solution, but I’ll do it for now. Assuming it fits.”

“Oh,” he pulls his hand out from under hers’ so he can slide the ring off, “I don’t think that will be an issue.”

A crease between her eyebrows shows her confusion.

He’d almost laugh if the situation wasn’t so serious. “Do you think I’m the same ring size as Emilie?”

Nathalie blinks, and them her face settles on an expression he’s seen before when she can’t understand how she’s missed something at work, “I hadn’t even thought about it.”

The ring sticks on his knuckle but then he gets it over and slides it off, “Not quite as flashy as a Miraculous but magic in its own way.”

He takes her hand to put the ring on in her finger but she goes stiff in his hold in a way he’s quite unused to, “Nathalie?”

“I uh,” there’s a pinkness to her cheeks, and he’s not sure how he’s flustered her, “think you might want my other hand.”

“Right,” he almost drops the ring in his embarrassment as he tries to switch, “wouldn’t want to give Adrien the impression you’d secretly got married.”

“Right.” She agrees, as he carefully places the ring finger of the *correct* hand, which *doesn’t* suggest any romantic attachment on Nathalie’s part.

The ring sits as perfectly on Nathalie’s finger as if it was made for her. Which he knew it would. But for some reason he finds it hard to look away from it even as she reaches for her tablet.

She does something on her screen. “Should I have one made for you?”

“One what?”

She looks up. “A replacement ring. There’ll be comment if you go out without one.”

The *sensible* thing, the *diplomatic* thing, to do would be to agree but instead he finds himself saying, “Maybe there should be comment.”

Nathalie doesn’t say anything leaving him room to expand.

“Maybe I *want* there to be comment. Maybe Emilie *deserves* comment. Because if she did *this,”* whatever exactly this is, “then maybe I never knew her at all, and if I never knew her then how much of a marriage did we really have?”

Nathalie inhales and puts the tablet down before leaning over to wrap her arm around his shoulders, “You’ll get your answers when you get her back.”

“Humph,” he doesn’t really give her reply because what he’d say—

*When will* that *be?*

*Assuming I* want *her back.*

*Have you a new plan that might actually succeed then?*

*What, so she can lie to me* again?

--anyway it wouldn’t be particularly helpful.

---

“Father,” Adrien smiles, and it’s *exactly* Emilie’s smile and Gabriel has to supress a wince because he’s not sure children are supposed to mimic their parents *that* much, “I almost thought you weren’t going to take me to the show.”

“Nonsense,” he says gruffly, squeezing Adrien’s shoulder in reassurance, “you’re my son. There’s nowhere else you should be.”

Somehow, *impossibly,* Adrien seems to see through his front, “I’m sure it will be a great show. I know you’ve been so busy working on it.”

Though apparently Adrien has completely missed what’s *actually* upsetting him. Though he can hardly blame him. It’s hardly the sort of thing you’d guess.

And best for Adrien to just assume he’s busy with work anyway.

“I have been,” he says, “it’ll be a relief to have it down.”

Now he *can’t* twist the boy with magic maybe he should make some time to observe him. It’s hardly like Nathalie can do that part of their research now.

---

“Nathalie I,” he stops taking in the unkempt bed with no Nathalie in it. “Nathalie?”

He finds himself turning his head to look around the room despite the fact that if Nathalie was anywhere here then she’d be in his field of view as it is.

She must be in the bathroom.

But he can't hear any sound from in there and as he stands there waiting she doesn't make an appearance.

Deeply aware of the awkwardness of the situation he walks over to the en-suite and knocks, "Nathalie?"

Still no answer.

And terror that sweeps through him for both his assistant and his son makes his push the, apparently unlocked he discovers, door open.

"*Nathalie?"*

No Nathalie.

There aren't words in any human language strong enough to express the feelings going through him right now.

In his idiotic panic he even checks inside her wardrobe and runs to check the quite obviously shut window.

He rings her phone only for it to vibrate where she's left it on her bed.

Nathalie would *never* leave this house without her phone.

Not willingly.

And Nathalie isn't well enough to leave either. The chance of her collapsing—

No.

Gabriel can't allow that.

If she's somewhere here he'll find her.

---

Adrien lies safely sleeping in his bed and with *that* some of his terror bleeds off but it doesn't answer the question of *where the hell is Nathalie?*

---

A light from the kitchen catches his attention and draws him in and he can only hope it's a true guiding signal and not some will-o'-the-wisp leading him astray because some idiot left the light on in here while Nathalie lies lost elsewhere.

The kitchen door too is empty but the door to the wine cellar lies open and *there* he finally finds Nathalie slumped down on the stairs.

The sight of her calms him somewhat but his heart is still beating frantically in his chest because she could have *fell,* she might be hurt, why on earth would she venture out of bed and down here?

Well technically the bottle of wine in one of her hands answers that question but it doesn't really answer it.

Nathalie's likes her wine as much as anyone does but she's no alcoholic. Putting herself, putting *Adrien,* in danger to sneak down for one is quite unlike her.

He kneels down ready to check her pulse but when he calls out her name she blearily opens her eyes, "Gabriel?"

"Nathalie what *happened?"*

"Oh," she looks a little confused and he doesn't like how her eyes don't quite seem focused, especially as the bottle in her hand is *unopened* suggesting it can't be blamed on the alcohol, "it's ok. I just had to sit down before I fell down."

That does not sound like it's in anyway ok to Gabriel, but anyway, "Why were you even down here?"

Her eyes slide to the bottle in her hand, "I just wanted to forget."

*Oh Nathalie.* He's put far too many burdens on her. He knows that.

"Come on," he reaches under her arms to get hold of her as her pulls them both up to standing. Thankfully Nathalie makes it easier by reaching over his shoulders with her hands meeting behind his neck but he doesn't like how much of her weight he's taking.

It makes him ask, "Can you walk?"

Nathalie hesitates then admits, "I don't know."

If she's admitting *that* much then he thinks probably it's a definite no.

He braces one of his hands on her hand moving the other down to her hips to lift her, "Can you hold on tight?"

"I can manage that," and when he feels her arms press down against his shoulders he lifts.

Nathalie obliges by wrapping her legs round him just above his own hips and he hadn't exactly been planning for that but it does make things easier and he feels more comfortable

with her more secure.

He feels more comfortable too with her solidity and warmth pressed around him safely confirming how he hasn't lost her after all even as he winces at the protrusions in her hip bones he doubts were there before.

Untransformed he's not quite sure he can carry her up the stairs to her room like this so he brings her to the living room instead sitting them both down on a chair.

Nathalie reaches down and puts that bottle of wine down on the table beside them.

Now he's here he's not quite sure what he's meant to do. She's not crying thank goodness but her melancholy mood leaks through the brooch on his chest.

Generally he avoids reading Nathalie or Adrien's emotions to the extent he can but it's hard when her heart is crying out for than Akuma. Awkwardly he rubs her back. He thinks that's something people do to soothe people.

"I just can't stop thinking about *her,*" she says, "My Ladybug."

His hand stills, *That* hadn't been what he'd been expecting. "Don't trouble yourself. We'll beat her soon enough."

"Not her," Nathalie looks up from where her face has been resting against him, "*My* Ladybug. The one I made."

"Ah," he realises the issue, "Nathalie that's not the same."

"Isn't it?" he's never heard her voice wobble like that before, and it almost scares him as much as it had when she'd thought he was missing, "Doesn't Sentibubbler haunt *you?"*

He inhales, and reaches for the bottle, having to awkwardly reach behind Nathalie so he can un-cork it and then he takes a swig.

Then he puts it down and makes his confession, "No."

"No?"

"My creation was not the same as Adrien at *all.* He was created for one task and that's it. He has no thoughts or desires of his own."

Nathalie stares at him then sits back so her chest no longer rests against his and reaches for the bottle. He grabs her hand to stop her, "is that wise?"

"What have we done recently that's been wise?"

He releases her.

She takes a gulp of her own, "*She* wasn't like that. *She* was capable of more than wanting the Miraculous, she did want more than the Miraculous. And I killed her. And I know it's not the

same. I keep telling myself that. Adrien's *grown,* he's been alive for years he's as much a person as anyone. And she, maybe she just acted as she did because I made her a too good copy of Ladybug. But I think I might be a murderer anyway."

"Nathalie,"

"I could kill someone I think," she continues spilling words as if she hasn't heard him, "if it was to save you or Adrien. No, I don't think. I *know* I could. But I always thought I'd at least know I was doing it."

Chapter End Notes

so, uh, I fooled myself thinking I could get this done in two chapters.

# Chapter 3: Re-evaluations

He scrolls through the translated fragments their contacts in China had managed to acquire for them at really quite an excessive price and at no little risk to keeping their identities secret.

*There's nothing.*

Nothing that explains what exactly Adrien is or how exactly they can free him from his amok.

*Useless.*

He could chuck the tablet across the room. He would if he was in his own room or in the Atelier but he's *not* and he has no wish to destroy *Nathalie's* belongings.

The sound of her own tapping at her screen stops. "I'm sorry about the other night."

"Forget about it," he says, "you've done as much for me before."

Though he doubts Nathalie had felt reassured *herself* when she'd been his support at the lowest of times the way *he* had with her in his arms that night.

It's terrible but it's *vindicating* to have her as lost by any of this as he is, and yet still here beside him aware of it all. Bringing her into his secrets was the right decision. Even if he *does* regret the hurt it's caused her. Both physically and emotionally.

That Ladybug. It doesn't bother him. Not really. She *wasn't* the same as Adrien. She'd never grown, she had no parents and no family.

But it does bother Nathalie.

He can tell.

It irks him that he can't fix it. Even as part of him wants to point out that for all the genius of her plan, for all he *doesn't* believe that Ladybug was equal to *Emilie* who they'd been trying to save and that would have made it worth it had they won, that if she'd come to him with it he'd have refused it.

Really. He doesn't understand what it is with the women in his life using the Peacock Miraculous behind his back to try to create people.

Despite coming to a halt in her work Nathalie hasn't looked away from her screen though she acknowledges him. "I'm not sure that's the same."

"It seems the same to me," he disagrees, Nathalie has gone *further* than her job requires of her by any stretch of the imagination. He'd wanted her loyalty and support. He hadn't wanted

her to risk her own life. It only seems fair to give a little back, “Anyway. Perhaps if we find a way to free Adrien then you could have your girl back too.”

Emilie had had Adrien. Nathalie can have her girl.

“What?”

“You’ve still the item you used don’t you?” He points out, “And, actually I don’t know whose emotion you used exactly. Is it one you could access again?”

Nathalie goes red, for some reason “um, yes, I could access it again.”

There’s something there but Gabriel doesn’t prod at it, if he embarrasses her then she'll only clam up,, “then, well,  I bring back the transformations from my akumas. I’m sure you could do the same.”

He watches Nathalie’s brows draw together. “But what would I do with her?”

“Raise her I suppose. You’ve the experience with Adrien, and it’s not like we don’t have the space.”

Ideally if Gabriel was going to bring another child into this house he’d rather prefer one which hadn’t already betrayed them once but then there’s no reason to have her know Nathalie’s Mayura.

Nathalie shakes her head. “That might be a little difficult considering I don’t know if that mask even comes off.”

“Yes, I suppose it wouldn’t help us with discovering who Ladybug is. An untransformed version of your creation would probably take after you.” Not a bad thing, he thought. It would certainly make things easier in a lot of ways, and he certainly wouldn’t object if she became more like Nathalie in personality.

It might even be helpful to have a companion for Adrien around.

“That’s a strange thought,” Nathalie says, “but I think maybe we should concentrate on Adrien for now.”

“Yes,” he agrees, “*Adrien* is the important thing. I just wish I knew more of what she’d done because Adrien *is* more isn’t he?”

Nathalie put the tablet down, “he *is.* He’s not indestructible, and I mean he gets *ill.* Surely he shouldn’t if he’s just a sentimonster? I’ve been trying to think if there was ever a time when he was ill enough that I could pinpoint *there,* that’s when she did it to save him and that's it but I can’t.”

“I should have known if Adrien was ever ill enough to die,” Gabriel points out, “he’s my *son.* I know I was busy with the company but surely Emilie would have told me that?”

Except Emilie hadn’t told him *any* of this whatever her reasons.

“Gabriel,” Nathalie sighs.

“I know. I know. Apparently I wasn’t worth telling anything about my son,” Gabriel takes his glasses off to pinch at his nose, “sometimes I wonder if he even is *mine.*”

“You said,”

“No I do consider him my son but look at him. He’s all *Emilie* there’s nothing of me there,” that’s part of why he’s always found Adrien so difficult to understand and now he wonders how he never thought that strange when surely he *should* have understood his own wife, “a good bit of chance that I’d always thought,” *Gabriel’s* not the one with the face to sell his brand, “but now I wonder if that was deliberate. If she didn’t *want* me in there.”

After all Emilie hadn’t mentioned any fertility issues. Gabriel hadn’t even really thought they were trying particularly hard for a child when she’d announced she was pregnant with Adrien.

He *wants* what he’d thought had happened, that Adrien had been conceived naturally, to be true but then he also doesn’t want what that might portend; that that child had died and that this Adrien is a replacement.

Perhaps it’s better if Adrien has *always* been as he is.

He doesn’t know. All he does know is that he just wants none of this to have happened. And if it did then Nathalie’s scenario is the best one— that the amok had just been some way of saving Adrien.

“We don’t know that Adrien’s always been like this,” Nathalie shifts position in the bed so she can take his face in her hands, and she forces him to look into her eyes, and their fervour seems almost to make them glow so that he has to at least believe *she* believes in what she says, “and *I* see you in Adrien. It’s not as obvious as Emilie true, but if you look past the eyes and the hair then there’s bits of you there in his face too. And you’re certainly there in his personality.”

He jerks back at that, and regrets it a second later with the loss of that warmth but, “*in his personality?”*

No one, not Emilie, not any of their extended family nor acquaintances have ever thought that, but there's a faint smile playing over Nathalie's face and her eyes soften in fondness as she says, “I’ve always thought so. There’s a very familiar stubbornness and you both love so very fiercely and,”

“And?”

She blushes again but clamps her lips together.

That does not bode well. “Nathalie tell me.”

“It's nothing.”

*"Nathalie,"*

"Well." She tilts her head slightly as if saying *you asked for this,* "You can both be a little ridiculous sometimes."

Gabriel could feel his jaw drop. "*Ridiculous?"*

"Adrien's quite creative. He ad-libbed some of Chat Noir's puns in the film you know? I think he'd do quite a good Hawk Moth impression if he put his mind to it."

Oh. That does touch him somehow but still, "but *ridiculous?"*

"It's charming."

"If you say so," he huffs even if he can't pretend that little smile she'd said charming with takes the sting out of it.

"Anyway, you know you're in Adrien. You did that secret DNA test when he was little and you were worried you'd taken Félix home by accident."

The embarrassment of that is still fresh years later. "Adrien was acting quite unlike himself."

"I think he was just upset at being separated from his cousin after spending the summer together."

That summer ranks amongst the worst of Gabriel's life. At least those which didn't actually involve losing people. He's lived in England. He can deal with British people, but Amélie and her husband's set of Sloanes had *really* pressed up against the limits of his capacity for that.

At least *he'd* been able to escape back to Paris with the excuse of work. Poor Adrien had been left behind and it had clearly had a detrimental effect on him.

Still, "perhaps," he allows, "though it doesn't really answer,"

"I know. And until we bring Emilie back I don't know that we *can* have an answer."

"*If* we bring Emilie back," he corrects her.

Her eyes narrow, "*If?*"

"We haven't been winning yet," he says because that's the *easy* bit to say. The bit he can admit.

"Gabriel,"

Then he surprises himself by saying the hard bit, "what would we be bringing her back *to?* What would be the point? How can I trust her now? How can I trust her with *Adrien?*"

"You can't believe she'd do Adrien *harm?*"

“I don’t know what she could do to him. Not anymore. Not with what we know now. And,” he swallows because it’s a horrible thought and selfish but, “I don’t know if I *want* her back. And how can I bring her back knowing that’s the case? What would I even say to her?”

He doesn’t know if he could even look his wife in the eye. Never mind feign enthusiasm for the return of someone who he doesn’t even know if he even knew. If he ever loved the *real* Emilie or just some sort of performance she put on for him.

“I don’t know,” Nathalie pulls the covers up, “but I don’t think it’s a choice you should make while you’re angry.”

It probably isn’t. And yet Gabriel finds it hard to care. He wants Emilie’s explanation. But he doesn’t want to deal with what Emilie’s explanation could be and live through it.

But right now he’s distracted by Nathalie’s attempts to cover herself up to her neck with the duvet, “are you cold? I could turn the heating up?”

“It’s alright.”

Irritation rise in him because, “you’re lying,” the way she keeps doing, the way *Emilie* had, the way they’d both been killing themselves with that bloody Miraculous, and it’s ridiculous to attempt it now because he can see, “you’re *shivering.* Stop pretending otherwise to me Nathalie. I don’t want any more lies.”

“Alright,” she snaps out, “I’m cold, like I’m quite often cold, and I’m in pain like I almost constantly am. Is that what you wanted to hear? Because what’s the *point* of me telling you? There’s nothing you can do. Not until you win.”

“No,” he admits and a slight coil of guilt unfurls in his gut about how his ambivalence about continuing must have liked like a disregard for her health , “I can’t cure you. But you don’t have to suffer in silence. We’ll have the doctor in again to take a look about painkillers and,” he slides off his jacket, “budge over.”

Nathalie’s eye’s go wide and her voice comes out unusually high pitched as she squawks, “*Sir?*”

The title feels wrong in the situation. She’s wearing his son’s soul on her finger. One would think that would make him *Gabriel* to her. He *had* been Gabriel to her earlier.

But then, he’s not completely obtuse. He does take her meaning, but he continues shedding his outer layers anyway.

“I hardly want to dirty your bed with my clothes,” he points out.

“Yes, but,” she splutters, and perhaps he *should* have gone and got his own pyjamas but they say bare skin is better for sharing body heat, or so he vaguely remembers. Nathalie doesn’t look away, but blinks rapidly, “I’m not sure this is appropriate.”

His hand stills over his Miraculous where he’s about to remove it to set aside for the night and it feels like he’s teetering over a precipice and as he says, “And everything else we’ve

done was?"

All *justifiable,* if perhaps teetering on the edge of it, but from how he'd happen asleep in her arms, to exactly he'd carried her up from the cellar, to how they'd stayed stuck together for that conversation after, he can hardly pretend it would look appropriate to someone who didn't know them and thought only of Nathalie as his employee.

Nathalie looks away from him down at her bed, "Perhaps not, but Gabriel *think* about it. What would Emilie think of this?"

"I find," he says, "that I don't particularly *care.*"

Perhaps Emilie wouldn't approve of this. But then Gabriel doesn't approve of what she's done with, done *to,* their son.

Nathalie's hand stops him where he's folding his blazer and waistcoat next to his bed. "Stop. Don't do this because you're angry at her. You'll regret it."

"I'm doing this my dear Nathalie," he tells her, "because I'm worried about *you.* If I wanted to take revenge on her I think I'd do rather more than attempt to be your hot water bottle."

He could try. Nathalie might even let him. And it *would* be satisfying. But whether it's the small part of his heart Emilie still occupies and she might forever occupy no matter what he's done, or the little voice at the back of his brain screaming at him not to drive Nathalie away, or some small scrap of morality he hadn't been aware he still had something holds him back.

"I see," her voice comes out rather strangled as he regards his folded clothes with satisfaction and climbs in beside her in his underwear.

She's still frowning as she lies down to match him and then, "Christ Nathalie your feet are icicles,"

It takes effort not to jerk away his leg from the one she's pressed up against his calf.

She keeps looking at the ceiling but he can see the smirk on her face, "I thought that was the *point."*

"Don't try and bring sense into my plans," he grumbles and, "you're still shivering, please tell me the rest of you isn't that cold."

"Probably not," she says, "I've always had bad circulation. Though I did think bringing sense into your plans *was* my whole job."

But she doesn't move and that single foot she's kicked out remains their single point of contact.

"Only most of it," he says rolling over to his side, "and only when I want you to."

Nathalie rolls over to face him, "well this isn't very sensible."

“Perhaps not,” he reaches an arm out over her and to his delight she shuffles forward, so he can properly embrace her up against him.

Despite it being the point he can’t pretend he’s *quite* as enjoying her equally freezing hands when she brings them up between their chests, and from her smirk he doesn’t do a good job hiding it.

“I don’t know,” Nathalie says sounding quite satisfied. “this might be better than you just turning the heating up after all.”

---

He’s jolted awake by a pinch to his arm and Nathalie’s voice saying, “Adrien I,”

*What.*

“Uh, no. Um.” Adrien’s talking from behind him, “I’ll just go. I’ll um. Text you about it. Since you’re, ah, busy.”

*Again?* Some part of him shrieks, *how many times does Adrien come into Nathalie’s room in the morning.*

Nathalie’s eyes are filled with panic but she’s yet to wipe Adrien’s memory the way he had so overall giving her the ring feels like the right thing to have done.

“I'm not busy,” she says, “if you need something then,”

“But you *are* ill,” he interrupts them, sitting up, “Adrien Nathalie’s had a terrible night of it. Unless this is urgent I suggest you ask another time. Or ask,” he's not sure actually, he’s transferred a lot of Nathalie’s work regards *Gabriel* elsewhere, but he’s not sure anyone’s duties cover *Adrien,* especially given Gabriel can hardly let another person in the house for obvious reasons. ”me. I suppose.”

Adrien’s just staring at them, and in retrospect if he’d known his teenage son was going to come in her room in the morning then he might have actually gone and got a pyjama shirt.

Simultaneously both Adrien and Nathalie speak.

“It’s fine I’ll ask you later.” From his son and “I threw up on his top.” From her.

“Oh.” Adrien seems to process her words, “oh right yeah that makes sense- wait, are you ok? Are you going to be ok? Do you have someone to look after you while Father’s working?”

“I'll handle that,” Gabriel says, “just go to school Adrien.”

Funny. He'd never thought he'd want to say that. But apart from his desire to get his son out of this room and this usually excruciating scene he’s almost willing to let Adrien have a little

outside experience if it makes him more complete.

“I'll do that,” Adrien pretty much flees out the door.

“I think I managed not to take control of him,” Nathalie murmurs, with a slight waver to her voice.

“I'd hope so,” Gabriel says dryly, “or I'm worried about that being your best scenario for the situation.”

“It could have gone worse.” She says, “Or maybe you could consider letting me lock my door again. I have to go into the bathroom whenever I get changed now so you and Adrien don’t walk in.”

“We’ve talked about this.” They *have,* “what if you faint or something and I couldn’t get in?”

She gives him an unimpressed look, “Papillombré could break that door down easily.”

“Yes, because *that* would be a fantastic thing for Adrien to see.”

“We could explain it,” she tucks some of her mussed hair behind her ear, “and talking of explaining things maybe you should eat with Adrien tonight to give yourself a chance to explain this.”

“I thought we just did.”

“Still,”

“I know.” It probably needs embellishment if he’s to stop Adrien thinking things the old-fashioned way. “And anyway what you said before was right. We can research Emilie’s notes, and about the Miraculous as much as we like, but we do need to observe Adrien too and in your condition I suppose that has to be me.” He has no doubt it will be excruciating but he’s done worse things for people he loves.

---

He’s not wrong about dinner. Adrien keeps shooting him awkward glances and then blushing.

He sighs. Politeness is one thing but he’d rather his son didn’t attempt to conceal things from him. “What is it Adrien?”

“Um.” And this manner of speaking Adrien’s picked up, with all its lack of confidence and fuller words irritates him, but it also reassures him because Emilie would never have designed him like that so it helps confirm his son’s reality, his *personhood*. “Nathalie. Is she going to be ok? If she was so unwell last night?”

“Last night was,” he doesn't want to give Adrien false hope but he doesn’t want to worry him either, but his usual method of giving no information won’t work here, “a setback, but she’s improving every day.”

“That’s good to hear,” Adrien hesitates, “I know you said there wasn’t anything, and I'm not trying to be rude but, you and Nathalie,”

“Are friends.” He shuts off his son’s hints. There's no need for *Adrien* to have any idea who comfortable he’s becoming with having Nathalie in his arms. “That’s all.”

That’s not all, but much of the rest is Papillon and Mayura, and thus even less fit topics for Adrien. Besides he’s married and Nathalie is, Nathalie is *ill.* Best not to dwell on how they’re the only person the other can rely on.

“Oh,” Adrien’s fiddling with that ring of his again, “how, um, *how* do you tell the difference between liking someone as a friend, and liking them as more?”

Gabriel swallows his irritation, this is *good* if Adrien’s thinking for himself, he’s *got* to remember that, but still he can’t help but sound unimpressed as he says “I think I'm capable of telling the difference Adrien.”

His son holds his hand up in defence, “I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to imply you didn’t it’s just-“

“Just *what* Adrien?”

“I’d kind of like to know. For me.”

For—

“You *like* someone?”

Isn’t Adrien too young for any of that?

He looks the boy up and down and—

Perhaps not.

Gabriel hadn’t noticed girls at that age, still more interested in the clothes being worn than the bodies but his soul recoils at the memory of how *other people* how acted at collége and at the idea that *Adrien* might be one of those lovestruck idiotic teenagers.

Oh god he needs Emilie back for this. For the first time since discovering Adrien is—

Adrien isn’t quite human.

And Gabriel hasn’t told him.

And Gabriel doesn’t plan to tell him, doesn’t *want* to tell him, because he and Nathalie are going to find a solution to the whole issue so Adrien never ever needs to know.

But he'd not thought about the fact that there were other people who might need to know.

Not *now.* Puppy love barely lasts.

Some part of him thinks maybe he could convince Nathalie to attempt bringing her girl back but more obedient this time just so they could give Adrien a girlfriend he *wouldn't* feeling uncomfortable about deceiving.

Not that he generally has much issue with deception but this feels too close to what Emilie had done to him.

Anyway there's no reason to think Adrien would be interested in her and the idea of his son dating someone they're present as what? Nathalie's adopted daughter? Niece? Just doesn't quite seem right.

But in the long-run.

Well.

In the long-run hopefully Adrien will have no idea he ever was other than wholly human.

But.

If they *don't* fix this quickly, the same way that they haven't fixed *Emilie* quickly then…

Will Adrien continue to grow and age?

Can Adrien even die of old age?

Can Adrien even have children of his own?

*Had Emilie even thought of any of this?*

Not for the first time he wants to know what exactly his wife was thinking.

And why she hadn't even thought to tell him after it became clear she was going to leave him as Adrien's sole parent for at least some period of time.

He knows she'd thought it would be less than it had turned out but at this moment for once he's not sure if he's more annoyed at her or himself for that.

Adrien is blathering on apparently unware of the Gabriel's horror and he realises that he's missed most of what's Adrien's saying.

"So it's hard to know." His son ends.

Gabriel really doesn't know how Emilie handled this sort of thing.

Ah.

Emilie had *known* that.

Had she thought that because he didn't have the instinctual connection with Adrien that she did that she couldn't trust him with their son?

God had she really thought he'd take advantage of her absence to dismiss their son and then what?

Lie about it?

He's suddenly yearning for her presence here far less.

Besides who knows what she'd say if she thinks Adrien's existence like this is fine.

But Gabriel knows what *he* wants to say.

"It doesn't matter."

Adrien blinks, *"what?*"

"You're too young to date. The very fact of the situation and your uncertainty shows that. And you don't have time either. The best thing you can do is ignore the situation and focus on your schoolwork. And maybe in a few years you'll understand better,"

"But,"

"And besides you know the press and half of your fanbase would come for any girlfriend of yours. Unless she's from a similar background it's unfair to expect any friend of yours to understand what they're getting into. Again being older will help that."

And perhaps Gabriel will have sorted all of this out by then too and he can let Adrien date with no more worries than other any perfectly normal boy.

Or perhaps not any normal boy because Adrien *is* exceptional, and even if Adrien was just his and Emilie's naturally conceived child then there's still so many pitfalls.

Probably the later he can push this back the better.

"Are *you?"* Adrien's eyebrows seem to be trying to escape from each other, "*banning* me from dating?"

He supposes, "Yes. I am."

Adrien opens his mouth again then seems to think better of it and close it.

But there's a mulish set to his mouth and Gabriel hasn't got this far in life, hasn't been any to sell so much to so many people, without being able to tell when someone is dissatisfied with what he's just told them.

And he can understand Adrien's point of view.

Almost.

It’s not like Gabriel doesn’t intimately understand the pain of love.

He softens slightly, “Adrien I want to protect you. Love is, it’s not just the pretty stories you read about or see in films. It hurts, and it’s full of betrayals and missed connections and sometimes you’ll meet someone and they’re be the centre of your live and then you’ll lose them and you’ll wonder if maybe it wouldn’t have been better never to have loved at all. I don’t want that for you.”

Adrien stands up suddenly, and Gabriel assumes he’s about to run out of the room in a strop and prepares to tell him off now that he safely can, but instead his son runs to *him.*

And throws his arms about him.

It’s strangely comforting in a way he doesn’t expect for all he objectively knows hugs are a form of comfort and he himself uses them as a tool of it.

This seems the wrong way round though. Emilie and Nathalie’s support is one thing. With Adrien shouldn’t *he* be the one caring for his son the way Emilie had not the other way round?

“I know it’s been hard for you,” Adrien says, “since mom disappeared. But you still have me, and Nathalie. You’re not alone.”

Sometimes he thinks it would be easier if he was.

He doesn’t actually want to be though.

# Chapter 4: Resolutions

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"The ironic thing is that I never actually wanted a child you know."

Nathalie's fingers still where they've been running through his un-gelled hair at his words, "did Emilie know that?"

"I didn't think so. I never mentioned it because, oh, I supposed I just thought that that was what you did when you got married. It's expected isn't it? People would say what's point of success like mine if you've no one to leave it all to?"

She's carefully neutral sounding in a way he recognises from work when she ask, "People?"

"Society. Emilie's family. Her friends. Everyone." People he'd like to claim he doesn't care about but whom he always found himself bending to the whims to anyway.

Nathalie hand resumes its movements, "And Emilie?"

Soothed by the motion he lets his eyes close as he relaxes into her lap, "Oh she'd have agreed. It was always *so* apparent that Emilie would want to be a mother. She lit up around children. So it never seemed worth mentioning after all I wasn't," he tries to get his thoughts in order, "*opposed* exactly. I didn't hate the idea. I just had no interest in it. But it seemed a fair price for Emilie, and as I say it was expected. But now I wonder if she *did* know."

He can tell Nathalie's frowning without seeing her. "I don't see how knowing you didn't want children would cause her to create one out of magic."

Gabriel can quite easily, "because she might not want to admit she couldn't have one naturally. I didn't think we were trying that hard,"

"You said,"

He opens his eyes. "But maybe she *was.* And maybe she'd sensed my disinterest and when she found it wasn't working she didn't want to have that conversation with me because she was afraid I'd have been glad of it."

"Would you have been?"

"No, not really. Emilie wouldn't have just given up like at a hurdle like that so I suppose I'd have followed her down whatever route she took to get herself a child and just felt annoyed it couldn't be easy and simple." But that lack of trust in him his wife must have had if his idea about what might have happened is correct rankles because, "but if she'd just *told* me I would have supported her. There was no need for *magic.*"

But then he'd thought that before all those years ago when Emilie had first heard of the Miraculous. Before he'd let himself get entranced by her impossible fairy stories and he'd started to believe that no one could *not* want to bend the world to their will.

Nathalie looks down at him, her fingers trail over his scalp. "You don't know that's why she did it."

"No," and that's the thing, "I suppose I never will."

Her expression changes to a pitying one, "Gabriel,"

"I know." He know she means well. She always does. "But there's not much point in lying to ourselves is there? *You've* read the same things I have."

He wonders if it looks odd to the heroes. How Papillombre has almost abandoned Paris and his quest for their Miraculous to appear randomly around the world. He's tried to keep it quiet but well, *tried,* is the operative word.

The worst part is how it's got to the point where it's dangerous if Gabriel Agreste is always in all those same places and he's had to resort to methods of transports quite below himself and ridiculous disguises and creating sentimonsters he can use to change his own appearance.

Honestly he's starting to regret not going after the Horse Miraculous when he had the chance. His two brooches can approximate the powers of the other Miraculous jewels with their akumas and amoks but they're always weaker in some ways than their inspiration.

And of course only Ladybug and Chat Noir has the necessary powers to grant him the wish he wants to make.

*Wanted* to make.

Nathalie sighs, "Saying it is admitting it. And I can't be the one to do so."

No. Gabriel supposes she can't. This always had to be *his* decision even before he'd fled the marital bedroom Emilie and her secrets seem to haunt for Nathalie's room at night. Not that they've done anything more than that. Not while Emilie lies below them slumbering.

But Emilie's not going to lie below them slumbering indefinitely because—

"If the damage to the Peacock Miraculous is related her creation of Adrien," to making a sentimonster that passes every test for being human, who *grows* and *learns, "*then reviving *her* would likely destroy him."

"It seems likely," she swallows, "we're lucky that fixing *it* didn't do it."

"God," he doesn't even want to consider that scenario. That he'd have been high on the rush of success of fixing the Miraculous only to return to the main parts of the house and find—

Find *what?*

Adrien unmoving, and still, and dead?

Adrien dissolving into nothing like any sentimonster Ladybug defeats?

Adrien gone before he got to him?

Disappeared the way all of Paris thinks Emilie has disappeared. Gone without explanation. And he'd never have known *how* or *why.*

What would he have thought?

That Adrien had *ran.* That Adrien had been *kidnapped.* That Adrien had fallen into the Seine by accident and got washed out to sea?

Would he have sat there night after night expecting his son to reappear never knowing that he'd killed him?

And what would the rest of Paris, the rest of the *world* have thought, Emilie disappearing is one thing but with Adrien that starts to look like a pattern.

They'd have been right of course. If more only technically so in Emilie's case to in Adrien's but he wouldn't have even known the latter and any investigation might have only exposed the only chance he'd have of getting them back.

And of course destroy what's left of his life.

He can't forget that. The brand would be in tatters, and Nathalie brought down with him and left to the mercies of a justice system that wouldn't make the necessary allowances for her health.

Nathalie's hand trails down from his head to *his* hand and as her fingers brush against his he entwines them.

She gives him a quick squeeze of reassurance, "she'd want you to put him first."

"Do you think so?"

It's funny. If Emilie *would* want him to let her go for Adrien's sake then by doing all of this and keeping it secret she's made it much easier for him to do so.

Before he's not sure who he would have picked. To have to chose *between* them seems like it would have been an impossible choice when neither of them would be happy without the other.

He can't pretend he wouldn't have been tempted by Emilie though.

Emilie who he'd loved first. Emilie who'd known him better. Emilie who'd *chosen* him, and not had fate create their relation.

Now it's different.

And now he's thought about how it would have been had *Adrien* disappeared and hadn't been going to come back and *he'd* been in the dark.

Well.

He thinks having concrete confirmation of his mother's death might *not* be the hardest thing for Adrien after all.

And from the pity in her eyes as Nathalie looks down at him he thinks she would agree too.

"No really," he tries to prompt her, "*do* you think she would?"

Nathalie worries at her lip, "I don't want to sound self-interested,"

"Don't. I know you wouldn't lie about this." He trusts her more than that. He always has.

"Then," she exhales, "*yes,* yes I do believe she'd want you to put Adrien first. She loved Adrien you know that."

"I do." Or he'd thought she had anyway. He still mostly believes it. It's impossible to believe that warmth in her eyes, and in her every motion with their son was all *acting* all that time however talented Emilie might have been.

However much she might have fooled him.

She'd accused him once of thinking of Adrien more as a doll, as an extension of his brand, of *himself* than as a child.

Now he wonders if that was projection.

After all she'd been the one who could command Adrien to do anything, be anything, with a single thought.

But no. He has to believe she loves Adrien. He has to believe that much is true.

Nathalie continues, "And if she wanted a child so much she'd create one out of magic, that only makes it more likely she'd want you to do *anything* to let that child live. And if she *knew* that sustaining Adrien was killing her then hasn't she already shown she's willing to die for him?"

And there is that. "I suppose so."

In some ways Adrien's existence while Emilie's body failed her is proof of exactly what Emilie wanted. Of what her final wish was.

"And, there's," Nathalie hesitates, "if it was me *I'd* want you to put Adrien first."

"You'd," his thoughts about his wife are abruptly derailed by images of *both* Nathalie and Adrien caught up in an akuma attack and him only able to rescue one of them. Of Nathalie getting *worse* and coughing up blood and *him* having to choose again whether to save the,

whether to save *Nathalie* or to free Adrien with the jewels he's been fighting for so long in his hands, "*what?*"

"I would. I always would. I," Nathalie blinks, "I *do.* If there's ever a time when you have to pick between me and Adrien I want you to pick *him.* I'm-"

He's not ready to accept that, not ready to lose her too, and he sits up so he can look her in the eye. "You're getting better."

"It doesn't matter. I want you to promise me to save Adrien. And I think Emilie would want you to do the same."

"I'd like to think so," and perhaps he's lying to himself, perhaps he's just trying to make this more palatable because he's about to do something he never thought he'd do, to do something that shatters his image of *himself* as much as Emilie's secrets had shattered his image of *her,* "because I have to let her go don't I?"

Despite the fact he's agreeing with her there's only a sort of resigned sadness in Nathalie's expression as she says, "I think you do."

"You know what the worst thing is?"

Nathalie's eyebrows draw together, "What's the worst thing?"

"Part of me hopes that she knew I didn't want children and she went behind my back to force me because," he sighs, "it's better than thinking maybe she didn't know and she thought I *did* and she did it this way because she didn't want to admit to being a failure to me. And now it's resulted with her dead, and me left with Adrien alone."

"You're not alone," Nathalie says.

"No," he reaches out to cup the side of her face, "I know I'm not. Not with you."

When Emilie's—

Once Emilie's—

*God.* He needs to be able to think it if he's actually going to do it.

When they've lain Emilie to rest he knows that he and Nathalie need to talk about the subject they're dancing around for all he's sure she's quite as aware of what's happening as he is, but that's a matter for the future.

For now what matters is that he has her, and the problem of what Adrien is isn't his burden alone.

"I never wanted children either," Nathalie admits, "I'd be a terrible mother."

"I'm not sure about that," Gabriel disagrees.

She seems to have better instincts about Adrien than he has. Perhaps even than *Emilie* had for all she lacks Emilie's open affection and spontaneity with Adrien. After all Adrien seems to be thriving at school even if it's fostering a rebelliousness Gabriel would hate if it wasn't a welcome sign his son can be more than his nature.

Besides after all these changes perhaps, but no, his imagined image of a Nathalie freer with himself and Adrien outside the confines of this room doesn't work, because Nathalie *can't* spend too much time with Adrien while she's still wearing that ring.

"Either way," Nathalie starts.

"It's ironic *we're* the ones left behind raising Adrien? Yes. I know."

---

Gabriel watches his son with talking, surprised animatedly in the circumstances, to a girl. One of his classmates. *Princess-Justice-As-Should-Have-Been.* Marinette. The girl Adrien *asked* to invite to the award ceremony.

Part of him that he can't turn off looks over her black dress in approval. If she hasn't made it she's tailored it. It fits too well for something off the peg.

He doubts Adrien's noticed with how he's yet to look away from the girl's hair loose hair. Gabriel vaguely recalls the girl's always worn it tied back when he'd seen her before.

It makes him glad Nathalie's stood there next to them on her crutches in her own stark black outift.

They might not plan to control Adrien but for all the Gabriel's never given a fig about manipulating any of his son's classmates for his old plans some of him still doesn't think the girl deserves to have Adrien fall into her arms while Adrien's still not-quite-human.

Because that's the other thing he sometimes wonders. Maybe Emilie didn't do this the way he thought. Maybe she had a different reason for wanting that Miraculous in the first place. Perhaps *she* was the sentimonster and she went in search of what could destroy her before anyone else could take control of it.

Maybe Adrien's condition is inherited.

It puts a different spin on Amelie wanting those rings back.

And talking of that witch, "Gabriel," Amelie's voice breaks into his thoughts, "I see you're not wearing any ring."

Gabriel has never been gladder that he and Nathalie had had the sense to put the ring on a necklace that's safely hidden under the high collar of her top for today. The idea of *Félix* getting the chance to control Adrien is the worst thing he can imagine.

“No. Your son stole mine if you remember.”

“Strange.” The temptation to shove her down into that grave next to her sister is strong but Gabriel forces himself to ignore it, as Amelie refuses to take the hint “I could have sworn I’d seen you wearing one in photos since.”

“A replica.” He says sharply.

“Hmm,” Amelie’s smile twitches, “since I imagine they must have found the one Emilie worn when they found her.”

Gabriel can’t look away from her as if she was a venomous snake crawling through the grass ready to bite at any time.

*How much do you know?*

Amelie *had* asked for both rings before back when Emilie was officially missing. A strange thing to do that he’d missed in his fury at her and at how Adrien’s suggestions about himself and Nathalie had thrown him off balance.

“Are you seriously bringing this up at your sister’s funeral?”

To think people call *him* callous. They’ve clearly never had to deal with his wife’s family.

“When else could I?” She says, “It’s not like you’d let me in your house.”

Frankly he wouldn’t have invited her to *this* if he could get away with it but unfortunately at the end of the day she *is* Emilie’s sister.

“Have some respect,” he says. “Don’t make a scene here. For *Adrien’s* sake if not your sister’s.”

“Remember that she *was* my sister Gabriel. Some of us can’t just replace her,” she looks over to Adrien, Nathalie and Marinette and sighs, “Adrien did well today. The piece on the piano you two played together was lovely.”

“He did.” Gabriel’s never been prouder of his son than he has been over how he’s held himself today and throughout everything since they had to break the news of Emilie’s death.

Adrien’s been *so* strong, and though Nathalie had confided that she worried that was *her* influence Gabriel doesn’t think it is. He thinks it’s just how Adrien is.

There’s a resilience in Adrien he’s noticed since he’s been spending more time with his son, *observing* his son that he quite lacks in himself. He doesn’t think it’s Emilie’s either. He likes that.

Nathalie looks up from the two teenagers with sympathy shining in her eyes as she catches sight of him with Amelie and he nods back acknowledging.

Then he watches the girl with them cast Adrien a very similar look. Frankly it's almost uncanny and if Adrien got *anything* from him he thinks he needs to speed up his plans.

*This* rising-star of a designer isn't going to be in the dark about the person she loves if Gabriel can help it.

"He's a good boy," Amelie says, "It's such a pity he and Félix aren't as close these days."

And with *her* next to him as an ever ready threat to Adrien's autonomy and existence he *really* needs to speed up him plans.

---

He exhales. "It's the only answer."

"Not necessarily," Nathalie shakes her head, "I'm going to keep looking. But it's certainly the only answer we know, and if Amelie's still after your ring then we can't delay."

Papillombre is going to have to make a reappearance in Paris and start chases those heroes again.

Because the *Wish* could make Adrien real. It could free him from his amok.

"No. we can't. You *know* what the only other thing we're seen break the link between a sentimonster and their amok before is and,"

Nathalie raises her eyebrows. "We're not cataclysming Adrien."

"Of course not," even if it *worked* the idea of risking Adrien like that is unacceptable, "anyway I doubt Chat Noir would just attack Adrien unprovoked and Adrien would never do anything to provoke the hero. And that wouldn't give him a soul anyway."

Nathalie frowns. "Do you believe in souls?"

Surprised at her reaction, he can't help but ask, "What?"

"Emilie's funeral is the first time I've seen you in a church in years. You didn't even go at Christmas."

"I don't have to believe in god to believe that something makes us *us,*" and that Adrien needs it, "and call it what you want but I *will* make Adrien real."

"I know," she says, "and I'm going to help."

"I know you will," he smiles and takes her hand, "Papillon and Mayura against the world."

"And *Mayura?*"

He shrugs, “Perhaps if you improve,” using both brooches together certainly doesn’t seem to be doing him any favours. “In the meantime it might have to be Papillombre and his lovely assistant.”

Nathalie pouts, “partner. I’m only *Gabriel’s* assistant.”

A smirk pulls at the corner of his lips and he leans in to press them to hers, languidly letting himself kiss her, as her mouth opens under his.

“You’re more than that,” he tells her as he pulls away.

They’re going to have to broach their changed relationship to Adrien at some point but Adrien isn’t stupid. He assumes his son knows already. And compared to everything else they could have to tell Adrien *this* one seems remarkably simple.

Though he knows Nathalie would prefer they wait until they’re succeeded and they can be sure his reaction to this news *is* his.

“I know,” she says with a more genuine smile than he’s seen from her in months. “And I know we’ll succeed Gabriel. We have to.”

“We have to,” he agrees.

Because what else can they do?

Defeating Ladybug and Chat Noir is their only option.

Chapter End Notes

So I think I found a way to make the reveal worse for Adrien?

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!